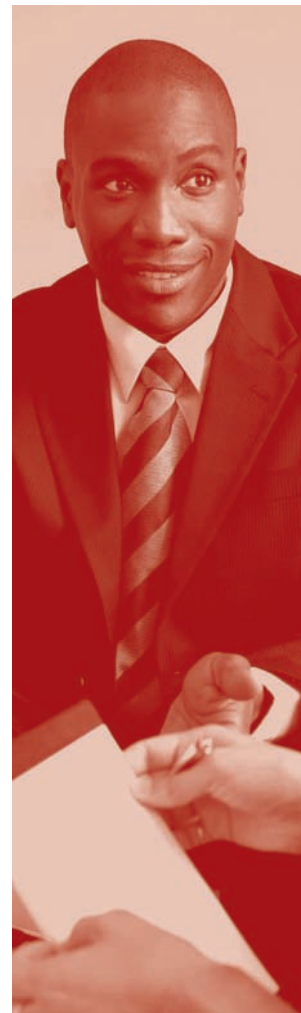


PEARSON NEW INTERNATIONAL EDITION

Training in Interpersonal Skills:
TIPS for Managing People at Work
Stephen Robbins Phillip Hunsaker
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PEARSON

Providing Feedback

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SELF-ASSESSMENT EXERCISE: MY FEEDBACK STYLE

For each of the following questions, select the answer that best describes you. Remember to respond as you have behaved or would behave, not as you think you should behave.

When giving feedback to another person, I:

	Usually	Sometimes	Seldom
1. Focus my comments on specific, job-related behaviors.	_____	_____	_____
2. Keep my comments descriptive rather than evaluative.	_____	_____	_____
3. Prefer to save up my comments so that they can be presented and discussed in detail during the person's annual performance review.	_____	_____	_____
4. Ensure that my feedback is clearly understood.	_____	_____	_____
5. Supplement criticism with suggestions for what the person can do to improve.	_____	_____	_____
6. Tailor the type of feedback to reflect the person's past performance and future potential.	_____	_____	_____

Scoring and Interpretation

For questions 1, 2, 4, 5, and 6, give yourself 3 points for Usually; 2 points for Sometimes; and 1 point for Seldom. For question 3, give yourself 3 points for Seldom; 2 points for Sometimes; and 1 point for Usually. Sum up your total points. A score of 16 points or higher indicates excellent skills at providing feedback. Scores in the 13–15 range suggest some deficiencies in providing feedback. Scores below 13 indicate considerable room for improvement.

SKILL CONCEPTS

Ask managers how much feedback they give subordinates and you're likely to get a qualified answer. If the feedback is positive, it's likely to be given promptly and enthusiastically. Negative feedback, however, often is treated differently. Managers, like most of us, don't

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particularly enjoy being the bearers of bad news. They fear offending the recipient or having to deal with defensiveness. The result is that negative feedback often is avoided, delayed, or substantially distorted.¹ The purposes of this chapter are to show you the importance of providing positive and negative feedback and to identify specific techniques to make your feedback more effective.

What do we mean by the term “feedback”? Feedback is any communication that gives people information about some aspect of their behavior and its effect on you.² Although our concern in this chapter is predominantly with performance feedback, the skill techniques presented here can be generalized to most types of interpersonal feedback. When you tell people sitting at an adjacent table in a restaurant that their cigarette smoking is bothering you, you’re providing them with feedback.

The Value of Feedback

An important reason to be skilled at giving feedback is that it can increase employee performance.³ This is true for a number of reasons.

First, feedback can induce a person who previously had no goals to set some. As we demonstrated in the previous chapter, goals act as motivators to higher performance. Second, when goals exist, feedback tells people how well they’re progressing toward those goals. To the degree that the feedback is favorable, it acts as positive reinforcement. Third, if the feedback indicates inadequate performance, this knowledge can result in increased effort, and the content of the feedback can suggest ways—other than exerting more effort—to improve performance. Fourth, feedback often induces people to raise their goal sights after attaining a previous goal. Finally, providing feedback to employees conveys that others care how they’re doing. Therefore, feedback is an indirect form of recognition that can motivate people to higher levels of performance.⁴

Positive versus Negative Feedback

We said earlier that managers treat positive and negative feedback differently. So, too, do recipients. You need to understand this fact and adjust your style accordingly.

Positive feedback is perceived more readily and accurately than negative feedback is. Positive feedback is almost always accepted, but the negative variety often meets resistance.⁵ Why? The logical answer seems to be that people want to hear good news and block out the bad. Positive feedback fits what most people want to hear and already believe about themselves.

Does this mean you should avoid giving negative feedback? No. What it means is that you need to be aware of potential resistance and learn to use negative feedback in situations in which it is most likely to be accepted.⁶ What are those situations? Research indicates that negative feedback is most likely to be accepted when it comes from a credible source or if it is objective in form. Subjective impressions carry weight only when they come from a person with high status and credibility.⁷ This suggests that negative feedback that is supported by hard data—numbers, specific examples, and the like—has a good chance of being accepted. Negative feedback that is subjective can be a meaningful tool for experienced managers, particularly those high in the organization who have earned the respect of their employees. From less experienced managers—those in the lower ranks of the organization and those whose reputations have not yet been established—negative feedback is not likely to be well received.

What We Know about Providing Feedback

Now it's time to look at basic feedback techniques. The following should guide you in determining how and when to provide feedback.

- 1. Focus on specific behaviors.** Feedback should be specific rather than general.⁸ Avoid statements such as “You have a bad attitude” or “I’m really impressed with the good job you did.” Those comments are vague, and although they provide information, they don’t tell the recipient enough to correct the bad attitude or on what basis you concluded that a good job had been done. Suppose you said something such as, “Bob, I’m concerned with your attitude toward your work. You were a half hour late to yesterday’s staff meeting and then told me you hadn’t read the preliminary report we were discussing. Today you tell me you’re taking off 3 hours early for a dental appointment.” Or “Jan, I was really pleased with the job you did on the Phillips account. They increased their purchases from us by 22 percent last month, and I got a call a few days ago from Dan Phillips complimenting me on how quickly you responded to those specification changes for the MJ-7 microchip.” These statements focus on specific behaviors. They tell the recipient why you are being critical or complimentary.
- 2. Keep feedback impersonal.** Feedback, particularly the negative kind, should be descriptive rather than judgmental or evaluative.⁹ No matter how upset you are, keep the feedback job-related and never criticize someone personally because of an inappropriate action. Telling people they’re stupid, incompetent, or the like is almost always counterproductive. It provokes such an emotional reaction that the performance deviation itself is apt to be overlooked. When you’re criticizing, remember that you’re censuring a job-related behavior, not the person. You might be tempted to tell someone they are rude and insensitive (which might well be true); however, that’s hardly impersonal. It would be better to say something such as “You interrupted me three times with questions that were not urgent when you knew I was talking long-distance to a customer in Scotland.”
- 3. Keep feedback goal-oriented.** Feedback should not be given primarily to dump or unload on someone.¹⁰ If you have to say something negative, make sure it’s directed toward the recipient’s goals. Ask yourself who the feedback is supposed to help. If the answer is essentially you—“I’ve got something I just want to get off my chest”—bite your tongue. Such feedback undermines your credibility and weakens the meaning and influence of future feedback.
- 4. Make your feedback well timed.** Feedback is most meaningful to recipients when only a short interval of time has passed between the behavior and the receipt of feedback about that behavior.¹¹ To illustrate, a football player who makes a mistake during a game is more likely to respond to his coach’s suggestions for improvement right after the mistake, immediately following the game, or during the review of that game’s films a few days later rather than to feedback provided by the coach several months later. If you have to spend time re-creating a situation and refreshing someone’s memory of it, the feedback you’re providing is likely to be ineffective.¹² Moreover, if you are particularly concerned with changing behavior, delays providing feedback on the undesirable actions lessen the likelihood that the feedback will be effective in bringing about the desired change.¹³ However, making feedback prompt merely for the sake of promptness can backfire if you have insufficient information, if you’re angry, or if you’re otherwise emotionally upset. In such instances, well timed might mean “somewhat delayed.”

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- 5. *Ensure understanding.*** Is your feedback concise and complete enough that the recipient clearly and fully understands your communication? Every successful communication requires transference and understanding of meaning. If feedback is to be effective, you need to ensure that the recipient understands it.¹⁴ Consistent with our discussion of listening techniques, you should have the recipient rephrase the content of your feedback to see whether it fully captures the meaning you intended.
- 6. *If negative, make sure the behavior is controllable by the recipient.*** There's little value in reminding people of shortcomings over which they have no control. Therefore, negative feedback should be directed toward behavior that the recipient can do something about.¹⁵ For example, to criticize an employee who is late because he forgot to set his alarm is valid. To criticize him for being late when the subway he takes to work every day had a power failure, trapping him underground for half an hour, is pointless. He could do nothing to correct what happened.

Additionally, when negative feedback is given concerning something that is controllable by the recipient, it might be a good idea to indicate specifically what can be done to improve the situation. This takes some of the sting out of the criticism and offers guidance to recipients who understand the problem but don't know how to resolve it.

- 7. *Tailor the feedback to fit the person.*** Our final piece of advice regarding feedback is to take into consideration the person to whom the feedback is directed. You should consider recipients' past performance and your estimate of their future potential in designing the frequency, amount, and content of performance feedback.¹⁶ For high performers with potential for growth, feedback should be frequent enough to prod them into taking corrective action, but not so frequent that it is experienced as controlling and saps their initiative. For adequate performers who have settled into their jobs and have limited potential for advancement, little feedback is needed because they have displayed reliable and steady behavior in the past, know their tasks, and realize what needs to be done. For poor performers—that is, people who will need to be removed from their jobs if their performance doesn't improve—feedback should be frequent and specific, and the connection between acting on the feedback and negative sanctions such as being laid off or fired should be made explicit.

CONCEPT QUIZ

Take the following 10-question, true–false quiz. The answers are at the end of the quiz. If you read the previous material carefully, you should get them all correct. If you miss any, go back and find out why you got them wrong.

Circle the right answer.

- | | | |
|-------------|--------------|---|
| True | False | 1. The givers and the receivers of feedback tend to treat negative and positive feedback differently. |
| True | False | 2. Managers should refrain from giving an employee negative feedback. |
| True | False | 3. Feedback, by definition, is concerned only with an employee's performance and its effect on you. |
| True | False | 4. Feedback tells people how well they're progressing toward their goals. |